

Adaptive leadership theory: Leading and following as a complex adaptive process

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Abstract

In this article, I develop a theory explaining how recurring patterns of leading–following interactions produce emergent leader–follower identities, relationships and social structures that enable groups to develop and adapt in dynamic contexts. In describing this emergent leading–following process, I attempt to shift the theoretical focus away from people as leaders or followers, and instead foreground the evolutionary value of a dynamic and fluid leading–following process. By emphasizing an interactive and contextually embedded process of leading and following in groups, this theory provides a theoretical basis for challenging the individualistic, hierarchical, one-directional and de-contextualized notions of leadership that permeate the existing literature.

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The field of leadership studies is entrenched in a conceptual crisis that severely limits our understanding of leadership in contemporary organizations. Despite claims that leadership theory is now focusing on “the more colorful aspects of leadership” and is making “giant leaps” of scientific progress (Avolio, Sosik, Jung, & Berson, 2003, p. 277), theories of leadership routinely portray leadership as overly individualistic, hierarchical, one-directional, and de-contextualized. Indeed, scholars have criticized leadership theories, both old and new, for conflating leadership with supervision and focusing on the behaviors and attributes of individuals at the expense of understanding the dynamic and social processes involved in leadership (Avolio, 2007; Bedeian & Hunt, 2006; DeRue & Ashford, 2010; Hosking, 2006; Rost, 1993; Zaccaro & Klimoski, 2001). Likewise, leadership theories are often criticized for understating the importance of followership and disregarding the social and contextual embeddedness of leadership in organizations (Grint, 2005; Howell & Shamir, 2005; Marion & Uhl-Bien, 2001; Uhl-Bien, Marion, & McKelvey, 2007).

In this article, I use these critiques as a launching point for developing adaptive leadership theory, in which I conceptualize leadership as a socially complex and adaptive process. I first identify a set of fundamental assumptions that are common across the dominant leadership theories, and explain how these assumptions have resulted in a collection of leadership studies that are often inconsistent with the basic definition of leadership. Scholars commonly define leadership as a social process of mutual and reciprocal influence in service of accomplishing a collective goal (Bass & Bass, 2008; Yukl, 2010). Yet, by focusing mostly on how individuals, often supervisors, influence their subordinates, the existing literature concentrates more on people as leaders or followers than it does the process of leadership (Hunt & Dodge, 2000). Relational leadership theories such as leader–member exchange (LMX; Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995) are an exception given their emphasis on relationships more so than individuals, but research on LMX often preserves the assumption that supervisors are leaders, subordinates are followers, and that these leader–follower identities are static. This person-centric and hierarchical approach to the study of leadership is particularly limiting in that it does not fully account for the social interactions and reciprocal influence patterns that enable leading–following relationships to develop and evolve over time.

After illustrating the deeply embedded nature of these assumptions about leadership, I explain how relaxing these assumptions enables the emergence of a more social and dynamic conception of leading–following processes in groups. Specifically, I conceptualize leadership as a social interaction process where individuals engage in repeated leading–following interactions, and through these interactions, co-construct identities and relationships as leaders and followers. These leader–follower identities and relationships are influenced but not entirely constrained by formal authority structures, such that the direction of influence in leading–following interactions can move up, down, and/or lateral in formal organizational structures. Over time through repeated interaction, these leader–follower identities and relationships emerge to form group-level leadership structures that range from centralized to shared patterns of leading and following. Yet, as group needs change, the pattern of leading–following interactions and the resulting leadership structures can evolve in ways that enable groups to adapt and remain viable in dynamic contexts (Hunt & Dodge, 2000; McGrath, 1962; Morgeson, DeRue, & Karam, 2010).

After developing this model of leading and following as a complex adaptive process, I then focus on theoretical integration. The leadership literature is replete with construct and theory proliferation, and as a result, scholars have called for more integrative theory-building related to leadership (Avolio, 2007; DeRue, Nahrgang, Wellman, & Humphrey, 2011). With this integrative aim in mind, I highlight how adaptive leadership theory extends the dominant theoretical paradigms in the leadership literature, including but not limited to trait, behavioral, and contingency theories of leadership. Moreover, I explain how this new conception of leading–following processes illuminates interesting research questions that would otherwise not emerge from more traditional perspectives.

Before moving ahead, I need to be explicit regarding several important boundaries of my theorizing. First, I limit my discussion of leading and following processes to group settings, and as a result, do not address many of the complexities associated with organizational leadership, including strategic leadership (Finkelstein, 1992; Ireland &

Hitt, 2005) and political leadership (Ammeter, Douglas, Gardner, Hochwarter, & Ferris, 2002). The context of organizational leadership would likely introduce different leadership needs and additional constraints on the leading–following process that might not be present in group settings. Second, I do not fully address the symbolic functions of leadership. According to Pfeffer (1977), leaders often serve as symbols for group success or failure. The present theory helps explain the social interaction processes through which some individuals come to be seen as leaders and therefore symbols of their group, but it is not clear that the symbolic functions of leadership are as dynamic as the leading–following processes portrayed in this paper. Finally, the current theory assumes that leading–following processes occur in all groups and have an impact on group functioning. Yet, the literature on substitutes for leadership (Kerr & Jermier, 1978) suggests that there are work factors that can attenuate the effect of leadership on groups. Although empirical support for this substitution effect is mixed (Podsakoff, Niehoff, Mackenzie, & Williams, 1993), it is important to recognize that the leading–following processes described in this paper are developed without explicit consideration of these possible substitutes.

1. Fundamental (and limiting) assumptions of leadership theories

Existing theories of leadership are rooted in and limited by assumptions about the conception of leadership, the relationships among actors who are engaged in the leadership process, and the relationship between leadership, the environment, and outcomes of interest. I contend that these assumptions, which I outline below, limit our understanding of the developmental and evolutionary aspects of leading–following processes in groups. For each assumption, I explain how that assumption is embedded in current theories of leadership and consider the theoretical implications of relaxing that assumption.

1.1. *Conflating leadership with hierarchical supervision*

With the exception of research on informal leader emergence (Bales, 1950; Morris & Hackman, 1969) and team leadership (Carson, Tesluk, & Marrone, 2007; Morgeson et al., 2010), leaders are generally thought of as having formal authority and managerial responsibility for a set of followers. Indeed, most leadership theories and empirical research are grounded in a context of supervisor–subordinate relationships whereby the supervisor is conceived of as the leader and the subordinate as the follower (Bedeian & Hunt, 2006; DeRue & Ashford, 2010; Hosking & Morley, 1988; Hunt & Dodge, 2000). Between 2003 and 2008, 84% of leadership research in management journals approached the study of leadership from this hierarchical perspective (Ancona & Backman, 2008).

For example, in transformational leadership theory, this hierarchical assumption is ubiquitous. In his classic article on transformational leadership, Bass (1990) introduces the transformational leadership concept by noting how “most relationships between *supervisors* and their employees are quite different today” (p. 19), and that “*managers* who behave like transformational leaders are more likely to be *seen by their colleagues and employees* as satisfying and effective leaders...” (p. 21).¹ Even when discussing transformational leadership across hierarchical levels, Yammarino (1994, p. 26) notes that “...leaders at all levels of an organization can influence the development and effectiveness of individual followers *at lower levels* regardless of whether the followers report directly to those leaders.” Thus, even when considering leadership across hierarchical levels, researchers assume that transformational leadership originates from people who are hierarchically superior. These same hierarchical assumptions are prominent in other contemporary leadership theories, including but not limited to ethical leadership (Brown, Trevino, & Harrison, 2005; Mayer, Kuenzi, Greenbaum, Bardes, & Salvador, 2009), leader–member exchange (Zhou & Schriesheim, 2010), and authentic leadership (Walumbwa, Avolio, Gardner, Wernsing, & Peterson, 2008).

Although formal hierarchical structures certainly influence who attempts to lead, who attempts to follow, and others’ reactions to those attempts, the prevalence of this hierarchical assumption is limiting. Supervisors are often not viewed as leaders in their organization (Bedeian & Hunt, 2006), and in many cases, individuals are seen as leaders despite not holding “leader-like” or supervisory positions (Charan, 2007; Charan, Drotter, & Noel, 2011; Spreitzer & Quinn, 2001). Therefore, preserving a hierarchical conception of leadership limits our ability to explain the development and effectiveness of non-supervisory leaders, or supervisors who fail to emerge or be identified as

¹ Italics are added on quotes as a point of emphasis.

leaders. Likewise, in cross-functional teams or ad-hoc groups where there is no formal authority structure, these hierarchical assumptions limit our ability to explain why some groups develop shared forms of leadership whereas other groups develop more centralized, vertical models of leadership (Pearce & Conger, 2003). Thus, while recognizing that formal hierarchies can influence the emergence and evolution of leading–following processes (Anderson & Brown, 2010; Galinsky, Jordan, & Sivanathan, 2008; Magee & Galinsky, 2008), we must also recognize that leadership, even within hierarchically structured groups, is not synonymous with hierarchy, supervision or formal authority.

Relaxing the assumptions of hierarchical authority for leaders and hierarchical subordination for followers has several important implications for leadership research. First, the act of leading can take on multiple directions, moving down, up, or across formal hierarchies. For example, subordinates can engage in actions that are traditionally viewed as leader behaviors, which in turn, can be reciprocated by acts of followership from actors who are hierarchically superior or equivalent. However, given the emphasis in the existing literature on inspirational motivation (Avolio, 2004; Bass, 1985), power and empowerment (Hollander & Offermann, 1990), and structural coordination (Halpin & Winer, 1957; Judge, Piccolo, & Ilies, 2004) as mechanisms through which supervisors “lead” their subordinated followers, it is not clear that current leadership theories can sufficiently explain this form of “leading up” or “leading across.” Indeed, there may be a completely unique set of mechanisms through which leading up or across hierarchy achieves its desired effects.

Another implication of not conflating leadership with hierarchy is related to the causal relationship between structure and behavior. The dominant perspective in leadership theory has historically been that hierarchical structures determine who is leading (supervisors) and who is following (subordinates). However, classic theories in sociology emphasize that structure is not exogenous to social processes. Rather, social structures such as hierarchy come to exist as recurrent social interactions, such as leading and following, take on predictable and socially shared patterns of behavior (Barley, 1990; Brass & Burkhardt, 1993; Buckley, 1967; Coleman, 1990). As Barley (1990, p. 64–65) noted: “. . . while people’s actions are undoubtedly constrained by forces beyond their control. . . it is difficult to see how any social structure can be produced or re-produced except through ongoing action and interaction.” In groups, for example, a subset of group members may be identified as leading the group’s actions toward a shared goal, while other group members are following. Even if this pattern of leading and following is legitimized through formal structure, the extent to which the leadership structure persists will be a function of how the leading–following interactions among groups members unfold going forward. If the pattern of leading–following interactions changes, a new pattern of relationships can emerge that, over time, becomes institutionalized and treated as a taken-for-granted fact until there is a new disruption or change in the pattern of leading–following interactions. Yet, by focusing mostly on “leaders” in formal hierarchical positions, the extant literature likely understates the effect of emergent leading–following interactions on the development of formal and informal leadership structures in groups.

1.2. *Portraying leadership as one-directional influence*

An important disconnect between definitions of leadership and existing research on leadership is related to the direction of influence. Definitions of leadership describe the concept as a social process of mutual influence among actors that is in service of accomplishing a collective goal (Bass & Bass, 2008; Yukl, 2010). In fact, an important distinction between leadership and traditional conceptions of social influence (Cialdini & Goldstein, 2004) is the bi-directional mutuality of the leadership process and the focus on a collective goal. Unfortunately, existing research on leadership foregrounds a one-directional process whereby one actor exerts influence over another actor. For example, consider Bryman’s (1986) description of leadership: “. . . leadership involves a social influence process in which *a person steers members of the group* toward a goal” (p. 2). This one-directional pattern is also evident in research examining upward, downward, and/or lateral influence attempts (Mechanic, 1962; Mowday, 1978; Schilit & Locke, 1982; Yukl & Falbe, 1990). For example, in Mowday’s (1978) study of upward influence, the focus was on the one-directional attempts of school principals to influence key stakeholders on decisions related to school budgets and resources, as opposed to a reciprocal influence process whereby principals influence and are influenced by these stakeholders in service of a common goal. Despite definitions of leadership specifying a mutual and reciprocal influence process, the existing literature presents more of a one-directional influence process.

This implicit assumption of one-directional influence is related to but distinct from the aforementioned assumption related to hierarchy. Even when scholars relax the hierarchical assumption, the leadership process that is described

often preserves a focus on one-directional influence. For example, in research on informal leader emergence, scholars maintain that leadership is something that one actor (the emergent leader) does to the rest of the group (e.g., Taggar, Hackett, & Saha, 1999). Similarly, the literature on shared team leadership foregrounds a one-directional influence process by focusing on how multiple group members “lead” by engaging in leader-like behaviors (Carson et al., 2007; Pearce & Conger, 2003), but the mutual interactions and followership responses that accompany these multiple, shared leadership attempts remain unexplored.

By implicitly endorsing a uni-directional influence pattern, prior research overlooks the behavioral interdependencies involved in the leadership process, and in particular, how actors co-construct the process of leading and following through mutual influence and the interdependent acts of leading and following (DeRue & Ashford, 2010). According to Hollander and Willis (1967), the basic unit for describing interpersonal influence is a double interact, whereby the behaviors of one actor are contingent on but also influence the behaviors of other actors. These double interacts form a contingent response pattern where future action is a function of prior interactions and feedback loops among actors. In the context of leadership, when an individual engages in a leadership act, the influence of that act on the leadership process and the group is contingent on the response of other actors (e.g., whether they follow or not). Moreover, it is the response of other actors that ultimately shapes how the focal individual engages in the leadership process going forward. Thus, actors engaged in the leadership process are both leading and following simultaneously (Hackman & Wageman, 2007), and the act of following is equally as influential as an act of leading.

When leadership is viewed as a series of interlocking acts of leading and following, several new insights emerge. For example, theories of followership have recently emerged in part due to the fact that leadership theories are silent on the role of followership (Collinson, 2006; Kellerman, 2008). Unfortunately, these theories of followership commit the same offense—they are generally silent on how following interacts with and is contingent on leading. Yet, if we conceptualize leadership as an interactional process of leading–following double interacts, it becomes clear that leadership and followership are inseparable. The implication is that existing theories need to be revised to account for the contingent response patterns and interdependencies that exist between them. In particular, the leadership process is such that one actor’s following (leading) gives meaning and legitimacy to another actor’s leading (following), and this interdependence is fundamental to our understanding of how leadership processes emerge and evolve in groups.

In addition, recognizing the interdependencies between leading and following brings to the foreground Barnard (1938) and Simon’s (1957) notion of a zone of acceptance. When one person engages in an act of leading, the intended effect and degree of influence is contingent on how that act fits within other actors’ zones of acceptance. Existing leadership theories that focus on a set of leader traits, behaviors, or styles implicitly assume that the leadership acts delineated in those theories are within other actors’ zones of acceptance, and as a result, produce followership. Yet, people have different zones of acceptance for leadership and followership. For example, a person in one situation with one set of group members may engage in charismatic leadership behaviors. Assuming those charismatic leadership behaviors are within the group’s zone of acceptance, the person displaying those behaviors may become recognized and endorsed as a leader in the group. However, that same person in a different situation or with a different group might engage in the same set of charismatic leadership behaviors, but because those behaviors are not within the group’s zone of acceptance, the result might be conflict over who is leading or the most effective approach to leadership. In this sense, understanding the impact of leadership requires also understanding the reciprocal acts of followership, and vice versa.

Finally, recognizing the behavioral interdependencies between leading and following also makes salient issues related to causality. Contrary to many leadership theories, the leadership process does not necessarily begin with an act of leading. Rather, acts of leading might be in response to another actor’s earlier acts of following, or might be motivated by another actor’s claim of leadership that is perceived to be illegitimate or insufficient (DeRue & Ashford, 2010). In sum, moving beyond the implicit assumption that leadership is a form of one-directional influence is essential for developing a more dynamic and social conception of the leading–following process.

1.3. Depicting leadership as a personal attribute

Dating back to great man theories of leadership (Galton, 1898) and perpetuated by numerous entity-based perspectives on leadership (Hosking, Dachler, & Gergen, 1995), the existing literature often assumes that leadership is something that an individual possesses (e.g., in the form of traits, attributes or skills) or engages in through specific behaviors (e.g., initiating structure, consideration, transformational, transactional behaviors). For example, House

et al. (1999, p. 184) defined leadership as “the *ability of an individual* to influence, motivate, and enable others. . .” Similarly, Schein (1992, p. 2) defined leadership as an “*individual’s ability* to step outside the culture. . .to start evolutionary change processes that are more adaptive.” In fact, even relational theories of leadership classify individuals as either leaders or followers (e.g., Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995), thereby treating leadership (and followership) as a property of the person. Unfortunately, this individualistic and person-centric perspective emphasizes the person as the source of leadership (or followership), and therefore does not fully account for the social and dynamic processes by which patterns of leading and following develop and evolve.

Similar to Bateson’s (1972, p. 334) call to “stamp out nouns” and Weick’s (1979) call to focus on organizing processes as opposed to organizations, the leadership literature would likely benefit from dropping the static labels of leader and follower. Instead, a focus on the interdependent acts of leading and following, and the process by which actors place meaning on those actions, is needed. Leadership is not simply an objective reality or static feature of a person. Rather, consistent with attributional approaches to the study of leadership (Calder, 1977), leadership involves a social interaction process whereby people engage in influence acts that are then socially constructed as leadership or followership. To illustrate the point, imagine someone who you consider to be an effective leader. Now ask yourself: does this person only lead, or does he or she also follow the leadership of others at particular moments in time? Everyone, at one point or another, leads and follows. If this is true, then leaders and followers (as static properties of individuals) do not exist. What exists are actions that are socially negotiated and constructed as leading and following, and when those acts recur over time, they become the basis for individuals’ identities as leaders and followers.

The idea of social construction in leadership research is not new (Grint, 2005; Meindl, 1995), but if we take seriously the tenets of social construction, some of the most dominant and well-established theories of leadership need to be revisited. For example, behavioral theories such as transformational leadership (Avolio, 2004; Bass, 1985) prescribe a set of behaviors that individuals engage in to be effective in leadership roles. These theories generally treat the idea that behaviors can be socially constructed differently across actors and environments as a boundary condition to the main effect of leader behaviors. However, social construction is likely not just a boundary condition in leadership. Rather, social construction is at the core of whether a particular behavior is conceptualized as leading, following, or something entirely different. For example, a person in one situation with one set of actors who attempts to establish a vision and direction for the group (a key leadership behavior in many theories) may be constructed as a leader in that particular setting. However, that same person who engages in the same behavior in a different situation with a different set of actors may be constructed as illegitimately trying to coerce the group in a particular direction or in violation of his or her role in the group. In turn, neither the person nor his/her behaviors are constructed as leader-like at all. Relaxing the assumption that leadership is a property of individuals appropriately shifts the focus of attention away from people as leaders or followers, and instead on the actions that people engage in and the social processes through which people place meaning on those actions.

1.4. Treating the environment as exogenous to the leadership process

The leadership literature is replete with contingency theories portraying leaders as most effective when they adapt to their environment (e.g., Fiedler, 1971; Houghton & Yoho, 2005; House & Mitchell, 1974; Kriger & Seng, 2005). In most of these theories, the environment is defined in terms of follower characteristics (e.g., ability, motivation) or situational elements such as task demands and structures. For example, House and Mitchell’s (1974) path-goal model of leadership proposes that leaders are most effective when they adapt their style to fit with subordinates’ personal attributes (e.g., ability) and situational factors such as task repetitiveness and position power. More recently, scholars have extended these theories by examining how individuals adapt their leadership styles based on follower attributes such as self-efficacy (DeRue, Barnes, & Morgeson, 2010), task characteristics such as disruptive events (Morgeson, 2005), organizational factors such as life-cycle stage and structure (Shamir & Howell, 1999), and societal factors such as culture and norms (Shin & Zhou, 2003). Common across these contingency theories is an assumption that the environment supplies the variation that individuals (“leaders”) must adapt to, and that this variation is exogenous to the leadership process.

Although framing the environment as exogenous to the leadership process appropriately presents leadership as an agentic process, it also advances a narrow conception of leadership as a mechanism of control. In most contingency theories, the primary function of leadership is to assess the source of environmental variability (e.g., followers,

situational factors) and match that variability with a leadership style or approach that best controls the (negative) effects of the environment on group functioning. However, treating the environment as exogenous to the leadership process does not fully account for the reciprocal ties that bind and relate the leadership process with the environment. Whereas leadership processes might sometimes be reactive to exogenous conditions in the environment, it is also possible that leading–following processes can create the environmental conditions that enable or constrain group effectiveness (Hackman, 1990).

To illustrate the interdependencies between leadership and the environment, consider the role of “followers” efficacy beliefs in the leadership process. Contingency theories frame these efficacy beliefs as an important constraint that leaders must adapt to (DeRue, Hollenbeck, Ilgen, & Feltz, 2010; Walumbwa, Wang, Lawler, & Shi, 2004). For example, research suggests that when group members have low self-efficacy, a coaching approach is an effective leadership style, but that a directive approach is more effective when group members have high self-efficacy (DeRue, Hollenbeck, et al., 2010). In this case, group members’ efficacy beliefs serve as a constraint on group functioning that team leaders adapt to. However, empirical research also suggests that leadership can impact followers’ efficacy beliefs (Dvir, Eden, Avolio, & Shamir, 2002) and that followers’ efficacy beliefs can impact individuals’ leadership styles (Dvir & Shamir, 2003). These recursive ties offer one illustration of how the environment influences but is also influenced by the leadership process. In this sense, the leadership process is more akin to Rajagopalan and Spreitzer’s (1997) description of strategic change processes, where organizations adapt their strategies to their environment, but over time, changes in organizational strategy influence the environment.

To be clear, I am not the first to call attention to how these assumptions limit our theories of leadership. As far back as Bennis (1959), scholars have noted the problems associated with conceptualizing leadership in bureaucratic and hierarchical terms. Likewise, scholars such as Meindl (1995), Sjostrand, Sandberg, and Tyrstrup (2001) and Grint (2005) have called attention to the social construction of leadership and challenged the notion that leadership is a property of the person. More recently, DeRue and Ashford (2010) challenged the uni-directional assumptions in leadership theory with their bi-directional model of leadership identity construction. There is clearly an emerging shift in leadership theory toward a more social, dynamic, and processual perspective on leadership (Uhl-Bien, 2006; Uhl-Bien et al., 2007). That said, this theoretical shift is being slowed by the absence of a common language and way of describing the leading–following process exclusive of these core assumptions. Without this common language, leadership becomes everything and therefore becomes nothing.

2. Leading and following as a complex adaptive process

In the present theory, I develop a multi-level model for the emergence and evolution of leading–following processes in groups (see Fig. 1). This model is based on five core propositions. First, the basic unit of interaction in the leadership process is a series of leading–following double interacts that take on distinct patterns of interaction over time. By focusing on leading and following as double interacts as opposed to formal positions, it becomes possible for all members of a group to engage in both leading and following acts. Second, these leading–following double interacts stimulate the construction of leader and follower identities, and this leadership identity construction process becomes the basis for leader–follower relationships in groups (Day & Harrison, 2007; DeRue & Ashford, 2010; Ibarra, Snook, & Guillen, 2010). Thus, two outputs of leading–following interactions are individuals’ identities as leaders and/or followers and the social construction of leader–follower relationships. The third proposition is that the emergent pattern of leading–following interactions develops within an environment and context that are endogenous, not exogenous, to the leading–following process. Fourth, the leading–following process is fluid such that actors can be leading and/or following at different points in time, and this interactional process produces and re-produces distinct patterns of leader–follower relationships in groups. These patterns of leader–follower relationships emerge to form group-level leadership structures, and although these leadership structures can be stable over time, they can also change such that who is leading at one point in time might be following at a different point in time. Finally, consistent with the principle of requisite variety (Ashby, 1956), I propose that a group’s ability to adapt in dynamic contexts is a function of how much variability exists in the pattern of leader–follower identities and relationships. As the environment becomes increasingly dynamic, a more fluid and variable pattern of leading and following should enable groups to adapt more effectively. At the same time, a variable pattern of leading and following can increase variability in the environment, and consequently create a positive feedback loop prompting greater demand for more fluid leading–following interactions in the future.

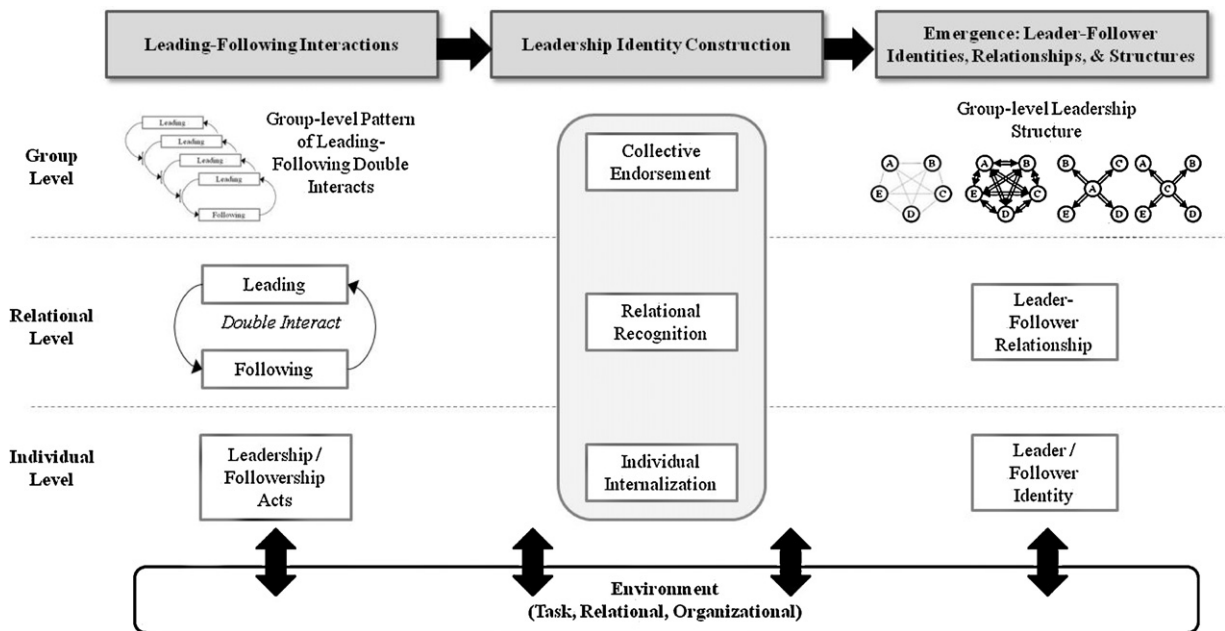


Fig. 1. Adaptive leadership theory: a conceptual model.

Altogether, these propositions depict a leading–following process that is not constrained by hierarchical, one-directional, individualistic, or de-contextualized notions of leadership. Whereas many existing leadership theories were developed at a time when large, bureaucratic organizations dominated the corporate landscape, the nature of work in contemporary organizations is more interdependent, dynamic and decentralized. As a result, there is an emerging perspective that leadership is more of an emergent and dynamic process where people can shift between leader and follower roles according to the needs of the group (Morgeson et al., 2010). The present theory attempts to explain how these leading–following processes emerge and evolve.

Proposition 1. *Leadership develops as a pattern of leading–following double interacts*

The basic unit of exchange in leadership processes is the interdependent and interlocking acts of leading and following. Specifically, the leading–following process consists of individual behaviors that are enacted among two or more people. When one person engages in leading (following) acts, those acts are a function of and contingent on others' following (leading) acts. This contingent response pattern is what Hollander and Willis (1967) and Weick (1979) referred to as a double interact, and is the basic mechanism through which social systems develop over time. Whereas most of the existing leadership literature focuses on the behaviors of a single individual (the “leader” or “follower”), conceptualizing leadership as a series of double interacts emphasizes that the emergence and effect of any given leadership (followership) behavior is contingent on the response of other actors.

The pattern of leading and following that emerges will depend on the magnitude and dispersion of leading–following double interacts. Magnitude represents the amount of leading and following acts being exhibited and reciprocated within a group. A high magnitude of leading–following double interacts indicates that an extensive amount of leadership acts is being exhibited by one or more group members, and that these leadership acts are being reciprocated by other group members' following. In contrast, a low magnitude represents a lack of leadership acts, or a lack following to reciprocate the leadership being exhibited by group members. Several empirical studies have established that the magnitude of leadership is positively related to group performance (Carson et al., 2007), but these studies do not account for the dispersion of leadership. The dispersion of leading–following double interacts reflects the degree to which, over time, leadership is centralized with a single individual, shared among all group members, or some intermediate configuration. Indeed, the concept of dispersion is at the core of an ongoing debate about whether leadership in groups should be centralized or shared (Pearce, Conger, & Locke, 2007), but it is also important to realize that these forms of dispersion can change over time. For example, the leading–following pattern might be highly

centralized at one point in time, but as group needs change, the dispersion could shift to a shared pattern. Although magnitude and dispersion are related, groups can have the same magnitude of leadership but dramatically different patterns of dispersion (centralized or shared), and these patterns of dispersion can change over time while the magnitude remains constant. Likewise, although the dispersion of leadership might be the same across groups, the magnitude of leadership in those groups could vary. Thus, to truly understand the form and pattern of leadership in groups, it is essential that researchers model both magnitude and dispersion.

Fig. 2 provides an illustration of the pure-type patterns of leading–following interactions that are possible when considering the magnitude and dispersion of leading and following in groups. These group-level patterns in leading and following can best and most precisely be expressed mathematically. The magnitude of leading–following double interacts is defined as the total number of leading–following double interacts being exhibited within a group, relative to the maximum possible number of leading–following double interacts in the group, and can be represented as a form of network density (Wasserman & Faust, 1994):

$$\text{Magnitude of leading–following double interacts} = \frac{\sum_{ab=1}^n X_{ab}}{n(n-1)}$$

where X_{ab} = the presence of a leading–following double interact between two actors (a, b). Double interact X_{ab} is present when actor A engages in a leading act, actor B follows, and actor A subsequently engages in another leading act. X_{ab} takes on a value of 0 if no double interact exists (e.g., actor A attempts to lead but actor B does not follow), or a value of 1 when a double interact exists between two actors (e.g., actor B does follow actor A's leadership attempt). Measuring X_{ab} requires assessing the extent to which the relationship among actors involves both leading and

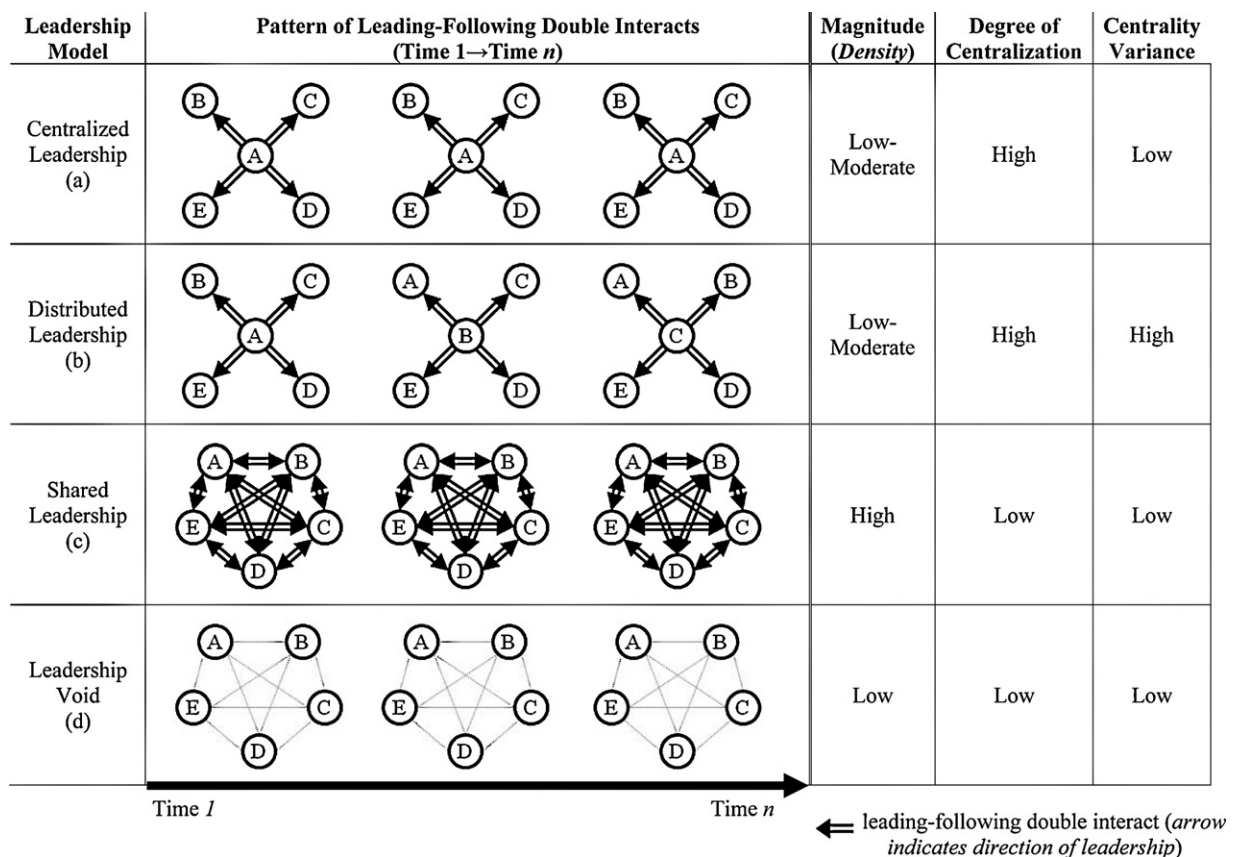


Fig. 2. Pattern of leading–following double interacts (actors A–E).

following. n = the number of actors in the group. The $\{n(n - 1)\}$ denominator indicates the maximum number of asymmetric relationships in a group. The magnitude ranges from a minimum value of 0 to a maximum value of 1.

A minimum magnitude (equal to 0) of leading–following double interacts suggests that no leadership acts are being reciprocated with following, and vice versa. In contrast, a maximum magnitude (equal to 1) indicates that there are many leadership acts being exhibited within a group and that those acts are being reciprocated with a proportionate amount of following acts.

Modeling the degree of dispersion in leading–following double interacts requires assessing two distinct properties of the leading–following process. First, the degree to which leadership is centralized or shared within a group will be important for understanding the basic structure of leader–follower identities and relationships in that group. This aspect of dispersion can be represented using Freeman's (1979) notion of network centralization:

$$\text{Degree of leadership centralization} = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n [C_{\max} - C_a]}{\max \sum_{i=1}^n [C_{\max} - C_a]}$$

where C_a is the outdegree centrality of actor in the leadership system. $C_{\max}$ is the largest observed centrality value. n is the number of actors in the leadership system (i.e., group). The $\{\max \sum_{i=1}^n [C_{\max} - C_a]\}$ denominator represents the theoretically observed maximum of the degree of leadership centralization in a group, which can be expressed as $[(n - 1)(n - 2)]$. Centralization ranges from a minimum value of 0 (leadership is fully shared) to a maximum value of 1 (leadership is centralized with one actor).

In a group with maximum centralization (equal to 1), all leading acts are originating from a single group member, and all other group members are following. In groups with minimum centralization (equal to 0), depending on the magnitude, either all group members are sharing in both leading and following (high magnitude) or nobody in the group is leading or following (low magnitude).

The second important property of dispersion is related to whether individuals are consistently assuming either a leader or follower role over time, or if individuals are shifting between leading and following. To assess this temporal aspect of dispersion, a centrality variance score is needed to assess the extent to which group members are, over time, shifting between leading and following. When there is low variance in indegree centrality, group members are consistently engaging in leading and/or following, but when there is high variance in indegree centrality, group members are actively shifting between leading and following. For example, in Vanderslice's (1988) description of leadership at a restaurant collective, individuals actively rotated leadership and followership responsibilities, which would produce a high degree of variance in indegree centrality at the group level. This centrality variance score can be represented with the following formula:

$$\text{Centrality variance score} = \left[\sum_{i=1}^g \left[\sum_{t=1}^n (C_{at} - \bar{C}_a)^2 \right] / n \right] / g$$

where C_{at} = weighted indegree centrality for actor a at time t . n is the number of time periods actor is present in the group. g is the number of individuals in the group.

As illustrated in Fig. 2, considering the magnitude, centralization and centrality variance of leading–following double interacts results in four distinct patterns of leading–following double interacts: centralized leadership, distributed leadership, shared leadership, and a leadership void.²

2.1. Centralized leadership

A centralized leadership structure emerges when an individual actor (actor A) is the focal source of leading acts in the group. Concurrently, other group members (actors B, C, D, etc.) engage in acts of following that are in response to,

² There are three assumptions embedded in this discussion of magnitude and dispersion that are important to highlight. First, I am assuming that the double interacts are complete such that acts of leading are met with corresponding acts of following, and vice versa. Second, I assume that only double interacts are important for describing the magnitude and dispersion of leading–following patterns. The result of this assumption is that the model does not fully account for attempts to lead or follow that are not reciprocated. Third, I assume that the reciprocal nature of leading and following occur in close temporal proximity. Thus, acts of leading or following that are not reciprocated within close temporal proximity would, in my model, get treated as incomplete double interacts.

enable, and reinforce actor A's leadership. Because the locus of leadership remains with one actor over time, the pattern of double interacts that emerges is such that one actor consistently leads and other group members consistently follow (Fig. 2a). This pattern results in a relatively low magnitude of leading–following double interacts because all of the leading–following interactions are reliant on a single “leader”. In mathematical terms, $X_{ab} = 1(n - 1)$ because following occurs when actor A leads, but the magnitude is relatively low because actor A is the only group member who is leading and being reciprocated with others' acts of following. In addition, this pattern results in high centralization because all leadership acts originate from a single source, as well as low centrality variance since there is no variability in who is leading and who is following over time.

Due to the hierarchical and individualistic assumptions of existing leadership theories, this centralized pattern of leading–following double interacts is the dominant leadership model in the extant literature. Yet, existing leadership theories generally do not fully account for the importance of followership in the emergence of this centralized leadership pattern. In fact, without reinforcing acts of following, the leading–following double interact would be incomplete and actor A would not be empowered by group members to consistently lead over time. As Katz and Kahn (1978, p. 529) note: “without followers, there can be no leader.”

2.2. Distributed leadership

Recognizing the limitations of hierarchical models of leadership, scholars have begun to conceptualize leadership as a series of acts that can be distributed throughout a group or organization. In this distributed model of leadership³, the requisite leadership functions are distributed among groups members via a division of labor across time (Gronn, 2002). At a particular moment in time, one actor serves as the primary source of leading acts, and other group members respond with corresponding acts of following. Over time, however, the acts of leading and following shift among group members. Actor A might be leading and the other group members following at one point in time, but then at a subsequent moment in time (e.g., as the requisite leadership functions and group needs change), actor B could be leading and the other group members (e.g., actor A) following (Fig. 2b).

At any single moment in time, a distributed model of leading–following double interacts is analogous to a centralized leadership structure in that leadership is an individual production constrained by the limits of a particular individual, as opposed to a collective process with multiple sources of leadership. Thus, similar to a centralized leadership pattern, the distributed model reflects a relatively low magnitude of leading–following double interacts. However, because the acts of leading and following shift among group members, a distributed model reflects greater dispersion of leadership over time. Specifically, centralization will be relatively low as multiple group members, over time, are leading and being reciprocated with following by others. Likewise, the group will exhibit high centrality variance as group members are shifting between leading and following. This distributed pattern of leading–following double interacts is evident in Bales' (Bales, 1950; Borgatta, Bales, & Couch, 1954) original research on leadership emergence in groups, and more recently in research on rotated leadership (Erez, Levine, & Elms, 2002; Vanderslice, 1988) and dynamic delegation (Klein, Ziegert, Knight, & Xiao, 2006).

2.3. Shared leadership

Similar to the distributed leadership model, shared leadership reflects a pattern where multiple group members are engaging in both leadership and followership. In the distributed model, multiple group members are engaging in acts of leading and following, but those acts are sequential and not concurrent. With shared leadership, however, the acts of leading and following are occurring simultaneously across time and actors. As illustrated in Fig. 2(c), across time, individuals in a shared leadership structure are consistently and collectively engaging in acts of leading and those acts are mutually reciprocated by collective acts of following, which are then reinforced and reciprocated by subsequent acts of leading among group members. Thus, shared leadership also entails shared followership. Whereas most leadership theories assume that the people who are leading are not following, individuals must both lead and follow for shared leadership to emerge. This pattern of leading–following produces a high magnitude and low centralization of

³ Prior research has generally treated distributed and shared leadership as synonymous (e.g., Pearce & Sims, 2002). However, I differentiate between these two models on the basis that sequential versus concurrent displays of leading–following should be treated as distinct.

leading–following double interacts, as all actors are both leading and following. This pattern also reflects low centrality variance because actors are leading and following concurrently, and thus their identities as both leaders and followers are invariable over time.

In recent years, models of shared leadership have become of increasing interest to organizational scholars (Day, Gronn, & Salas, 2004; Morgeson et al., 2010; Pearce & Conger, 2003). However, the emerging literature on shared leadership has focused exclusively on the magnitude of leadership without considering the centralization or centrality variance of the leadership process (e.g., Carson et al., 2007; Pearce & Sims, 2002). The implication of this focus on magnitude presents an important limitation for understanding the pattern of leading and following in groups. DeRue, Hollenbeck, et al. (2010) illustrated using the concept of collective efficacy that groups can have the same magnitude (on a particular construct) but fundamentally different patterns of dispersion (e.g., a shared or bimodal distribution). Therefore, with respect to understanding patterns of leading and following, it is possible that the patterns of leading and following found in prior studies of shared leadership might not have been shared at all. In addition, it is not clear from prior research how shared following can accompany and initiate shared acts of leading. For example, research on shared leadership suggests that having more group members engaged in leadership behaviors, relative to fewer group members, is more effective (e.g., Carson et al., 2007; Mehra, Smith, Dixon, & Robertson, 2006). However, from these studies, it is unclear how the shared acts of leading depend on and foster collective acts of following. To fully understand shared leadership and its implications for group functioning, researchers must examine shared leadership as a collective process of leading that is initiated by, accompanied by, and followed by a collective process of following.

2.4. *Leadership void*

In groups where there is low magnitude, low centralization, and low centrality variance in leading–following double interacts, a leadership void emerges such that few group members are engaging in reciprocal acts of leading and following (Fig. 2d). In this sense, a leadership void is not simply a function of individuals failing to lead. Rather, a leadership void reflects a general lack of leading–following interactions in a group. Therefore, a leadership void can emerge when group members attempt to follow but no one is attempting to lead, thus producing a diffusion of responsibility (Wallach, Kogan, & Bem, 1964). Alternatively, a leadership void can emerge when group members attempt to lead but those acts of leadership are not reciprocated with acts of following. Although leadership voids are often discussed as a lack of leadership, it is important to recognize that a leadership void can also reflect a lack of following, which might arise due to low credibility of the person attempting to lead, political maneuvering, or leadership attempts that are ambiguous or not visible to others.

Proposition 2. *Leading–following double interacts enable the construction of leader–follower identities, relationships, and structures*

Early theories of social systems (Blumer, 1962; Mead, 1934; Parsons, 1951) emphasized that social configurations such as role, status and power relationships are not simply a function of formal structures that are imposed on people, but rather people socially construct these roles and relationships through social interaction. As Blumer (1962, p. 189) noted, social structures “are the product of the activity of acting units and not of ‘forces’ which leave such acting units out of account.” Drawing on these ideas, DeRue and Ashford (2010) and DeRue, Ashford, and Cotton (2009) theorized that the leader–follower roles and relationships observed in organizations are not simply a function of formal hierarchies or authority structures, but rather are the product of a social and dynamic identity construction process. Whereas prior social constructivist accounts of leadership focused on misattributions of leadership and performance (Meindl & Ehrlich, 1987), DeRue and Ashford explained how social construction processes also account for the development of leader–follower relationships.

In this leadership identity construction process, individuals claim leader and/or follower identities for themselves and grant leader and/or follower identities to others. People can claim a leader identity through acts such as referring to oneself as a leader or displaying particular identity cues (e.g., looking the part; Swann, 1990), or grant a leader identity to others by deferring to them in a meeting. Likewise, people can claim a follower identity via acts such as not speaking up unless called upon, or grant a follower identity to others by not including them in an important decision. To the extent that claiming acts are reciprocated by granting acts, subsequent claiming acts are prompted and the construction of leader and follower identities ensues. Importantly, these claims and grants are not mutually exclusive in that people can claim or grant both leader and follower identities, and the identity construction process can be initiated by either

claims or grants. Over time, repeated claiming–granting interactions result in individuals internalizing identities as leaders and/or followers, those identities becoming recognized in relationships (e.g., actor B sees actor A as leading and actor A sees actor B as following), and ultimately the identities being collectively endorsed within the broader social and organizational context. In this sense, assuming that those who engage in leader or follower acts recognize and label them as such, the claiming–granting process is one mechanism through which leader–follower relationships develop.

Extending DeRue and Ashford's (2010) theory to the group level, I posit that each configuration of leading–following double interacts (centralized, distributed, shared, void) will be associated with a distinct pattern of leadership identity construction, and that this leadership identity construction process will be a central mechanism through which leading–following double interacts produce group-level leadership structures. For example, group members in a shared configuration are leading and following concurrently, and through these leading and following acts, claiming and granting identities as both leaders and followers. In comparison, in a centralized configuration, one actor engages in acts of leading while all other actors engage in reciprocal acts of following. Assuming these leading and following acts represent claims and grants of leader and follower identities, this centralized structure implies that one actor is consistently claiming a leader identity while other actors are reciprocating those claims by granting a leader identity to that individual and claiming a follower identity for themselves. As this double interacting cycle repeats over time, individuals' identities as leaders or followers (but not both) should become more deeply internalized in their personal identities, mutually recognized in their relationships, and collectively endorsed in the broader group context (DeRue & Ashford, 2010).

In contrast, the distributed and shared configurations should produce a highly dynamic and variable leadership identity construction process. In a distributed pattern of leading–following double interacts, one actor claims a leader identity while granting a follower identity to others, and those claims and grants are reciprocated and supported by subsequent claims and grants from other group members. Yet, the claiming and granting of leader and follower identities shifts among group members over time, such that one actor who claims a leader identity at one point in time will subsequently grant a leader identity to another actor and claim a follower identity for him or herself. This dynamic and shifting pattern of identity construction can occur in micro-moments of interaction, or over longer periods of time. In either case, the result is leader and follower identities being negotiated and re-negotiated over time, and individuals shifting in and out of both leader and follower identities (although not concurrently). In a shared configuration, individual actors are concurrently claiming both leader and follower identities, and simultaneously granting those identities to others. As a result, the distributed and shared patterns stimulate an identity construction process whereby individuals internalize and become recognized as both leaders and followers.

In framing leadership development as a process of identity construction, this proposition challenges traditional notions of leadership as a social influence and exchange process (e.g., Scandura & Schriesheim, 1994). The leader–follower relationship has historically been framed as an exchange relationship where leaders and followers exchange resources. For example, leaders might offer more meaningful work tasks, liking and social capital, or rewards in exchange for followership and compliance. From this perspective, the leader–follower relationship is based on who possesses resources and is willing to exchange those resources in return for leadership or followership. In contrast, the current theory frames leading and following not as an exchange of resources but as a process of negotiating leader and follower identities through social interaction. That is, individuals through interlocking claims and grants are engaging in identity work that communicates and gives shape to their reciprocal identities as leaders and followers. These identities then become the basis for emergent leader–follower relationships and group-level leadership structures.

Another important implication of this proposition is related to the stability of leading–following relationships over time. Conceptualizing leadership as a dynamic and social process of identity construction allows individuals to shift between leading and following within the same group context. However, stability and continuity in leader–follower relationships is not only possible but also likely in many settings. In centralized patterns of leading and following, the leader–follower identities and relationships can become quite stable over time. Yet, this continuity in leading–following relationships is not simply a function of formal authority structures. Rather, stability in leader–follower relationships is the product of a social construction process where people, through repeated patterns of social interaction, co-construct consistent identities as leaders and followers. A stable pattern of leading–following interactions can emerge even in contexts where there are minimal authority differences (e.g., boards of directors, task forces). Alternatively, it is possible for leader–follower identities and relationships to change even when a formal authority structure is present, for example when subordinated individuals form a coalition to force a transition of power

and leadership to someone other than the formal “leader” (Mintzberg, 1984). Thus, the basis for continuity or change in leader–follower identities and relationships is the pattern of leading–following interactions that emerge in a group, which will be influenced but not entirely defined by formal authority structures.

Proposition 3. *Environments are endogenous to the leadership process*

The interlocking acts of leading and following, and the identity construction process that ensues, are embedded within an environment that spans across at least three levels of analysis: relational, task, and organizational. With respect to the relational environment, leadership processes occur among actors who are interconnected via social networks and influenced by relational histories and cultural differences that shape their mutual interactions (Balkundi & Kilduff, 2005; Brower, Schoorman, & Tan, 2000; Gerstner & Day, 1994; House, Hanges, Javidan, Dorfman, & Gupta, 2004; Mehra et al., 2006). Leadership processes also occur within task environments that influence the need for leadership and how leading–following processes unfold (De Hoogh, Den Hartog, & Koopman, 2005; de Vries, Roe, & Taillieu, 2002; Lord & Rowzee, 1979; Morgeson, 2005). At yet a higher level of analysis, leading–following processes take place within an organizational environment where factors such as culture and norms (Jung, Chow, & Wu, 2003; Schein, 1992), governance structures (Pawar & Eastman, 1997), and managerial discretion (Hambrick & Finkelstein, 1987) affect how leadership processes develop and their impact on group functioning.

Historically, scholars have mostly assumed that these relational, task and organizational environments are exogenous to the leadership process, and that these environments impose variability onto groups that “leaders” must then react to and manage (e.g., Fiedler, 1971; Houghton & Yoho, 2005; House & Mitchell, 1974; Kriger & Seng, 2005). However, the double interacts of leading and following are not simply reactions to an environment. The leading–following double interact can also influence the environment, or at least how the environment is perceived. For example, prior research has documented how leadership processes can influence organizational culture and norms (Koene, Vogelaar, & Soeters, 2002; Schein, 1992), relational qualities such as trust and communication (Avolio, Jung, Murry, & Sivasubramaniam, 1996; Moenaert, Caeldries, Lievens, & Wauters, 2000), and task characteristics such as perceived autonomy and significance (Piccolo & Colquitt, 2006). Thus, whereas the environment influences leading–following processes, the leading–following processes can also influence the environment.

The recursive relationship between leadership and the environment is particularly salient in O’Toole, Galbraith, & Lawler (2002) account of shared leadership at a Midwestern manufacturing company. In this case, environmental factors such as family ownership and interdependencies between business units motivate a shared leadership model using co-CEOs. However, this shared leadership model ultimately produces confusion related to decision-making rights, a lack of trust among employees, and competition among CEOs over who is leading at different points in time. As a result, a need for leadership emerges in order to address the ambiguous task structures and relational strain among employees. Whereas the environment (e.g., family ownership) motivated the initial construction of a shared leadership model, the leading–following interactions that ensued among the co-CEOs created problems that then prompted a different set of leading–following interactions. Thus, the leading–following process was not only influenced by the environment but also influenced the environment in ways that determined the need for leadership in the future.

Proposition 4. *Variability in leading–following interactions enables leader–follower identities and relationships to adapt and evolve*

Not only do leadership theories commonly situate the environment as exogenous to the leadership process, but most leadership theories also frame environmental variability as detrimental to group functioning unless managed appropriately. For this reason, leadership is often framed as a mechanism of control designed to react to and/or reduce environmental variability. For example, scholars have suggested that “...leaders attend to restrictions imposed by time frame, resources, system demands, conflicting goals, and conflicting problems in generating and implementing potential solutions. ... (and) determining how to work within these restrictions may, in fact, represent the most common manifestation of leader innovation” (Mumford, Zaccaro, Harding, Jacobs, & Fleishman, 2000, p. 15). Consistent with this problem-solving orientation, scholars have portrayed the purpose of leadership as minimizing disruptions to group functioning (Morgeson, 2005; Morgeson & DeRue, 2006). As Morgeson (2005, p. 498) states: “the occurrence of (disruptive) events or problems offers (leaders) the opportunity to contribute...” Accordingly, environmental variability is framed as a problem to be controlled.

Although leadership certainly plays an important problem-solving function, environmental variability such as changes in task demands, group composition, or resource constraints is not necessarily dysfunctional nor should it

necessarily be minimized (Buckley, 1967; Weick, 1979). Without these forms of variability, groups may see less of a need to evolve their patterns of leading and following, thus producing overly fixed and institutionalized leader–follower identities and relationships. As a result, individuals who internalize and then become permanently recognized and endorsed as “followers” may, over time, also internalize a lack of voice (Detert & Burris, 2007), learned helplessness (Martinko & Gardner, 1982), and dependency on others (Kark, Shamir, & Chen, 2003). Indeed, this internalization of a “follower” identity might explain why people are less willing to take on leadership responsibilities when they do not hold a formal position of power or authority (Wellman, 2011). Likewise, it has also been shown that novel and disruptive events are essential to developing individuals’ capacity for leadership (DeRue & Wellman, 2009; McCauley, Ruderman, Ohlott, & Morrow, 1994). By seeking to minimize disruptions from an “external” environment, traditional perspectives on leadership could be undermining the opportunity for individual growth and development.

As an alternative, I propose that there are at least two ways in which variability in patterns of leading and following can enable groups to develop and adapt in dynamic contexts. The first is related to how the leading–following process enables group members to collectively process and develop a common understanding of their environment. Individuals are often biased by existing cognitive schemas and prior history when perceiving their environments (Katz & Kahn, 1978; Simon, 1957; Weick, 1979). The process of leading–following double interacts, however, can illuminate discrepancies in individuals’ understanding of their environment and focus attention toward reconciling these inconsistent views. For example, in management successions, the successor’s initial leadership acts espouse a particular understanding of the environment, including the group’s priorities and the style of leadership that is needed or wanted. This perception of the environment may or may not be consistent with how other group members view the situation. Importantly, how existing group members respond to the successor’s acts of leadership (e.g., compliance, debate, or competing claims for leadership) will communicate information about the form and pattern of leading–following interactions that is needed or preferred. In this sense, variability in leading–following interactions can be the antecedent to a meaning-making process where group members are able to actively negotiate, make sense of, and develop a common understanding of their environment (Drath & Palus, 1994; Podolny, Khurana, & Hill-Popper, 2005). It is important to recognize, however, that this variability could also be perceived as a threat to the power and authority of a formal manager, which might engender defensiveness and political maneuvering that impairs a group’s ability to develop and adapt to change.

Another mechanism through which variability in leading–following double interacts might enhance group functioning is related to the development of more adaptive group-level leadership structures. At one moment in time, actor A might be seen as leading and all other group members (B, C, D, and E) following. However, as the environment changes, a different leadership structure might be required to meet the needs of the group. For example, actors C and D might be needed to step up and lead while other groups members (A, B and E) follow, thereby requiring that the group evolve from a centralized leadership structure to a mix of distributed and shared leadership. As situations call for different people to take on different roles (as leaders and/or followers), variability in the pattern of leading–following interactions allows individuals to take on the roles that best meet the needs of the group, and not simply the roles prescribed by history or formal structures (Yetton & Bottger, 1982). An illustration of this variability can be observed in research on top management teams, where group members shift in and out of leader and follower roles based on whose expertise is most applicable to the strategic decisions being made by the group (Finkelstein, 1992; Finkelstein & Hambrick, 1996). In fact, by allowing individuals an opportunity to experiment with identities as leaders (or followers) that might not have previously been considered part of their possible or ideal selves (Higgins, 1987; Markus & Nurius, 1986), variability in leading–following interactions could be a source of individual growth and identity elaboration. Thus, the leadership process is not only a mechanism of control, but also a mechanism through which groups and their members can develop and adapt.

Proposition 5. *Leadership effectiveness is a function of reinforcement and requisite variety in the leading–following process*

Despite a wide range of leadership effectiveness criteria being used in prior research (DeRue et al., 2011), these criteria generally focus on the effect of an individual “leader” on follower, group and/or organizational outcomes. This individual-focus is consistent with the ego-centric and hierarchical assumptions embedded in most leadership research. The one exception is research on team leadership (Morgeson et al., 2010; Zaccaro, Rittman, & Marks, 2001), where the focus is not on an individual leader but rather how the aggregation of leadership among individuals is

associated with group functioning. Yet, even in team leadership research, the criterion for effectiveness is not focused on the inner workings of the leadership process or how leading and following are distributed among group members. Rather, the focus is on the association between an aggregate amount of leadership displayed by individuals and group performance (Carson et al., 2007).

For understanding the effectiveness of a leading–following process, existing conceptualizations of leadership effectiveness are limited in several important ways. First, according to theories of complex social systems (Buckley, 1967; Katz & Kahn, 1978; Weick, 1979), the effectiveness of social systems is not a function of the performance of individual components (e.g., the “leader”). Rather, effectiveness is a function of the organization of components and how these components, through their reinforcing interactions, enable the social system to develop and adapt. By extension, an important aspect of leadership effectiveness will be the extent to which leading–following interactions are reinforcing. In fact, reinforcing acts of leading and following are a necessary condition for centralized, distributed or shared patterns of leading–following interactions to emerge. If leadership attempts are not reciprocated with acts of following, or followership attempts not reciprocated with acts of leading, a leadership void emerges. Because no real pattern of leading–following interaction materializes, chaos could ensue such that who is leading and who is following are unrecognizable or nonexistent, and as a result, the ability of the group to adapt in dynamic contexts would be severely limited.

Another important limitation of existing conceptualizations of leadership effectiveness is that they privilege structural order and relational stability—for example, the assembly of task structures and harmonious relationships that enable groups to get along and perform well. Indeed, Weber’s (1978) original notions of bureaucracy were based on the value of structural order and stability. However, dynamism and change can be the norm in modern organizational contexts, and it is possible that variability in the pattern of leader–follower identities and relationships (e.g., shifting from centralized to shared and then to distributed patterns of leading and following) could be functional for group adaptation.

Consistent with the principles of requisite variety (Ashby, 1956) and akin to prior research on how organizations must navigate a delicate balance between stability and flexibility (Lawrence & Lorsch, 1967; Leana & Barry, 2000), I posit that leading–following processes will be most effective when the variability in leading–following processes is proportionate to the variability in the group’s environment. When groups operate in particularly stable environments, there is potentially less of a need for variability in leader–follower identities and relationships. In these stable environments, efficiency in group member interactions can be quite functional for group performance and adaptation (Hollenbeck et al., 2002), and it is possible that less variable leader–follower identities and relationships (e.g., the same people are leading and others following over time) will enhance the efficiency of the leading–following process. In dynamic contexts, however, group needs shift due to changes in the environment and it is unlikely that those needs can always be satisfied by a single pattern of leading and following (DeRue, Hollenbeck, Johnson, Ilgen, & Jundt, 2008; Morgeson et al., 2010). For example, as situations change, who is leading may need to shift among group members (a distributed pattern), or the group may need to shift from one leadership structure to a completely different structure (e.g., shift from shared to centralized leadership). Thus, whereas contingency theories focus on matching different leadership approaches to specific environmental conditions, the current model emphasizes an equilibrium between leadership and the environment. Specifically, leadership effectiveness will be highest when the variability in leader–follower identities and relationships is equal to the amount of variability in the group’s environment.

3. Theoretical implications and future research

In this paper, I attempt to bring the interactional nature of leading and following to the foreground. Instead of disaggregating the leadership process into individuals who are defined as leaders and other individuals defined as followers, conceptualizing leadership as a complex adaptive process shifts the theoretical focus toward a dynamic leadership development and evolutionary process where individuals co-construct their identities as leaders and followers via distinct patterns of social interaction. Through this leader–follower identity construction process, individuals co-construct leading–following relationships, and these relationships become the basis for the emergence of group-level leadership structures (centralized, distributed, shared, void). Although these leadership structures can be stable over time, they can also be quite dynamic as the pattern of leading–following interactions in a group changes. Indeed, I posit that this flexibility in the emergent pattern of leader–follower identities, relationships, and structures is a key mechanism through which groups effectively develop and adapt in dynamic contexts.

By framing leading and following as a complex adaptive process, adaptive leadership theory provides a basis for challenging and extending existing theories of leadership in organizations. In particular, the present theory invites questions about the fundamental definition and purpose of leadership, provides opportunities for extending existing theories of leadership, and highlights interesting research questions about the process of leadership that would otherwise go unexplored. My aspiration is that these research questions stimulate new ways of thinking about how we define, model and study leadership.

3.1. Implications for the definition and purpose of leadership

3.1.1. Reconsidering whether leadership requires a collective goal

Most theories of leadership presume that leadership is in service of a collective or shared goal. Indeed, a common definition of leadership is as a social influence process that motivates and enables a group of individuals to achieve a collective goal or shared purpose (Bass & Bass, 2008; Galinsky et al., 2008; House et al., 1999; Yukl, 2010). Likewise, scholars routinely assert that a primary role of leadership is to ensure that group members adopt a shared vision or goal (Bass & Avolio, 1994). This perspective is grounded in a hierarchical and individualistic conception of leadership in that it assumes a hierarchically superior individual can impose a set of goals and interests on subordinate individuals, and that those subordinate individuals will collectively embrace those goals and interests as their own.

However, in an emergent leading–following process, it is unlikely that goals and interests are simply imposed on individuals. Rather, social structures such as the pattern of leader–follower relationships emerge from a recurrent pattern of actions and interactions among individuals who can have diverse goals and interests. As suggested by Wallace (1970), social structures – for example, a centralized or shared leadership structure – emerge as individuals realize that, in order to achieve their individual goals (ends), they must come together and engage in a common and interdependent set of actions (means). Over time, these interdependent actions may give rise to a shared goal, but this shared goal is conceived in service of preserving the collective structure so that individuals can continue fulfilling their individual interests. In fact, individuals may not even need to realize that their goals differ, as long as they know that attaining their individual interests requires engaging in collective and interdependent action (Katz & Kahn, 1978). Importantly, relaxing the assumption of shared goals does not negate the possibility of organizationally imposed goals being seen as means to personal ends.

Extending these ideas to leadership in groups, it becomes possible that leadership processes may not require a shared vision or goal at all. In fact, the idea of a shared goal being super-ordinate to individual goals and interests may be a fallacy created from the hierarchical and authoritarian assumptions embedded in most leadership theories. It was this general disregard for individuals' interests that prompted the emergence of servant leadership theories (Graham, 1991; Greenleaf, Spears, & Covey, 2002), but these theories maintain a focus on how individual “leaders” achieve results by prioritizing the needs and interests of their followers (often confounded with subordinates). Thus, in theorizing about leadership as an emergent leading–following process, we may need to relax the assumption of a shared goal or purpose, and instead, examine how the leading–following process provides a mechanism for collective action that enables individuals to fulfill their diverse goals and interests, in concert with or in the absence of a collective goal.

3.1.2. Balancing structural order with variability in leading–following interactions

In the present theory, I explain how leading–following interactions can be a source of variability in leader–follower identities, relationships, and group-level leadership structures. It is important to note, however, that this perspective does not deny the functional benefits of hierarchy and structure (Halvey, Chou, & Galinsky, 2011). Indeed, formal hierarchies and authority structures will have an important influence on the emergent pattern of leading–following interactions. However, for the pattern of leading–following interactions to adapt in service of meeting a group's evolving needs, the form and structure of that hierarchy need to be flexible so that individuals can take on identities as leaders and/or followers and vary the patterns of leading–following interactions. The pattern of leading–following interactions needs to be in service of group needs, and those needs may or may not be congruent with the prescribed hierarchy. In this sense, even when there is a designated manager or formal leader, the leading–following process needs to allow for variability in the emergent pattern of leading–following interactions (Wellman, 2011).

In emphasizing the value of variability in leader–follower identities, relationships and structures, several important research questions emerge. For example, it is currently unclear when and under what conditions the leading–following

process promotes variability in leading–following interactions, as opposed to a stable set of leader–follower identities and relationships. Likewise, current contingency theories of leadership do not fully explain when groups should adapt their pattern of leading–following interactions. For example, research explaining when groups should shift from centralized leadership structures to distributed leadership structures, or distributed to shared leadership structures, would be particularly insightful. Given that groups may not always have the skill to recognize the need for change in leading–following interactions, or the autonomy to enact those changes, this research also needs to clarify the strategies and tactics that groups can use to adapt their patterns of leading and following.

Thus far, I have focused mostly on the impact that changes in the pattern of leading–following interactions might have for group-level adaptation. However, it is also likely that variability in leading–following interactions will have a profound impact on the individuals involved in the process. Research exploring how individuals experience and process variability in leading–following interactions, and the impact that this variability has on individual development, would be particularly noteworthy. Whereas shifting leader–follower identities and relationships could promote greater identity complexity (Roccas & Brewer, 2002) and enable individuals to explore a broader range of possible selves (Markus & Nurius, 1986), it is also possible that variability in leading–following interactions might promote confusion about individuals' identities and roles within groups. To this end, research examining how individuals experience variability in leading–following interactions and when this variability is functional for groups and their members would be noteworthy.

3.2. Implications for trait and behavioral theories of leadership

3.2.1. Reframing the role of individual differences in the leadership process

Trait theories of leadership suggest that individuals' dispositions and attributes (e.g., personality, motives, values) determine their effectiveness as leaders either through a direct effect on behavior or by manipulating others' attributions or perceptions of the individual (DeRue et al., 2011; Lord & Maher, 1991). The present theory offers a third alternative. With the exception of a leadership void pattern, I have presented a theory of leading–following processes in groups that assumes individuals are motivated to act in the best interests of the group, and as a result, will reciprocate leading with following and following with leading. Likewise, I have generally assumed that the co-construction of leader–follower identities, relationships and structures is a fairly smooth process without much disagreement or conflicting interpretations of leading–following interactions. However, individuals' unique experiences, personality, motivations, beliefs, and values will create differences in how people engage in leading–following interactions, what they see as leadership or followership in those interactions, and how they process information about the nature of their leading–following interactions.

For example, it is possible that individuals with a strong need for power or strong social dominance orientation (Pratto, Sidanius, Stallworth, & Malle, 1994) might overlook other individuals' claims for leadership, prescribe less legitimacy to those claims, or be more likely to interpret behavior as a claim of followership as opposed to leadership. Similarly, individuals who have a deeply held belief that groups are more effective when structured hierarchically, or what DeRue and Ashford (2010) refer to as a hierarchical leadership–structure schema, may view others' claims for leadership as a competitive threat to their own leadership. In contrast, individuals with more of a shared leadership–structure schema may interpret those same claiming actions as a contribution to the group, and therefore be more likely to support those claims with reciprocal grants (DeRue & Ashford, 2010).

In these examples, individuals' personal dispositions or traits are not directly producing a particular set of leadership or followership behaviors, or inducing a particular set of attributions from others. Rather, the primary mechanism through which these individual differences are influencing the leading–following process is by shaping how individuals socially construct the nature of leading–following interactions. This perspective is consistent with research on the development of leader–member exchange relationships, where individual differences not only influence how people engage in leader–follower exchanges but also how they interpret and perceive those exchanges (Phillips & Bedeian, 1994; Uhl-Bien, Graen, & Scandura, 2000). In the future, research on the individual differences that explain how people socially construct and process their leading–following interactions would be particularly insightful.

3.2.2. Determining the pretext for leadership and followership behavior expression

Behavioral theories of leadership such as initiating structure–consideration (Fleishman, 1953; Halpin & Winer, 1957) and transformational leadership (Bass & Avolio, 1994) dissect the content of individuals' actions and assert that

certain actions (but not others) are effective in governing group functioning. An important limitation of these theories is that they promote a particular set of behaviors without fully considering how the social context shapes why individuals engage in those behaviors in the first place. Although there are exceptions (Bommer, Rubin, & Baldwin, 2004), when prior research has considered the antecedents to such behaviors, the focus has been on how individuals' personality (Judge & Bono, 2000), motivations (Chan & Drasgow, 2001), or prior experience (Avolio, 1994) predict the display of leadership behaviors. Similarly, the research on followership (Baker, 2007; Kelley, 1988) preserves a focus on individuals' traits and attributes as explanations for followership, as opposed to considering how the social context affects behavior.

Yet, if the basic form of interaction in the leadership process is a leading–following double interact, then the social context – and in particular the behavior of others – will be an important antecedent to individuals' displays of leadership and/or followership. For example, an individual may engage in leadership behaviors not because of a particular trait or motivation, but because another individual in the group signals, through behavior, that leadership is needed or expected (e.g., by deferring to that person). Alternatively, an individual may attempt to lead through any number of behaviors, but if that behavior is not met with reciprocal followership from others, an important question is how many unsupported leading–following cycles are needed to affect future leadership behavior (e.g., when does a person give up attempting to lead). Equally important are the effects on followership, for example when group members attempt to follow another group member but that group member does not reciprocate with leadership behavior. In this case, it is unclear how many unsupported grants of leadership will be required before the leading–following double interact breaks down and members of the group begin to feel confused or look elsewhere for leadership. Thus, future research should investigate how individuals' leadership and/or followership behaviors are a function of the leadership or followership behaviors of other group members.

3.3. Implications for leadership emergence and development

3.3.1. Modeling change in the pattern of leading–following interactions

Day (2000) made a valuable distinction between leader and leadership development, with the former focusing on individual development and the latter focusing on system development. To date, most leadership development research has focused on the individual leader (see Avolio & Gardner, 2005 and Yammarino, 2000 for special issues addressing the topic), while very little research has examined how the leadership process, in terms of leader–follower identities, relationships, and structures, evolves and develops over time.

In terms of leadership development, an important question for future research is related to how leading–following double interacts can take on different structural patterns (i.e., centralized, distributed, shared, void) over time. At one moment in time, a group's leadership structure may be centralized because there is a need for one actor to be leading and everyone else to be following, but as the situation changes or the relational dynamics between group members change, that same group could take on a distributed or shared leadership structure, or a void of leadership might emerge. Despite considerable attention directed at understanding the impact of centralized and shared leadership on groups (e.g., Pearce & Sims, 2002), it remains unclear what factors affect the emergence of different leadership structures or the extent to which groups shift between different structural patterns. Drawing upon the present theory and other relational theories of leadership (Hosking & Morley, 1988; Uhl-Bien, 2006), future research needs to specify the interactional processes by which leadership relationships and structures are produced and change over time.

3.3.2. Reconciling exchange-based perspectives on leadership development with the social construction of leading–following processes

Leadership is commonly framed as a social exchange (Dienesch & Liden, 1986; Graen & Uhl-Bien, 1995; Hollander, 1978) where leading–following relationships emerge as individuals exchange – for example, their followership in response to another actor's leadership – in return for tangible (e.g., career promotion) and/or intangible (e.g., a positive image, liking) resources. In contrast, the present theory adopts a social constructivist perspective, where individuals' identities as leaders and followers and the pattern of leading–following relationships emerge based on how people make sense of and place meaning on their interactions with others.

These two perspectives, social exchange and social construction, are in some ways incompatible explanations for the development of leading–following interactions. Exchange-based theories posit that resources are the primary

mode of exchange and basis for the emergence of different patterns of leading and following. In contrast, a social constructivist perspective suggests that it is a socially constructed and negotiated meaning-making process that explains why different patterns of leader–follower identities and relationships emerge in groups. Likewise, exchange-based perspectives implicitly assume that individuals are fixed entities and it is the resources available for exchange that change. For example, the contingent reward approach to leadership (Bass, 1990), which is a classic exchange-based approach, implies that “leaders” and “followers” remain constant but the rewards (or punishments) that are used to motivate followers can vary. In contrast, constructivist accounts of leadership development imply that the actors involved in the leading–following process can evolve (e.g., internalize different leader and/or follower identities over time), and that the nature of leading–following relationships among actors can vary over time. In this sense, a social interactionist perspective assumes that individuals are dynamic entities who can develop and evolve their leader–follower identities and relationships over time.

The social exchange and social interactionist perspectives offer unique insights into leadership processes, and future research that integrates the two perspectives would advance a more comprehensive theory of leadership development. For example, research could examine how social construction processes influence the effect that resource exchanges have on the development and evolution of leading–following interactions. Whereas one person’s following in one situation might enhance his or her image or liking with another person (a common form of social exchange), that same following action in another situation or in exchange with another person could be socially constructed as social loafing or not contributing to the group. Conversely, resource exchange mechanisms could potentially minimize the degrees of freedom people have in how they socially construct their leader–follower identities and relationships. For example, significant discrepancies in the control over valued resources such as expertise or rewards could limit the degree to which some people could be socially constructed as leaders or followers, especially in settings where people equate leadership with power or supervision.

3.4. Methodological implications, challenges and opportunities

The present theory has significant implications for the research designs and methods that scholars use to study leading–following processes in groups. For example, the fundamental unit of analysis in this theory is the leading–following double interact that occurs among actors. Thus, rather than aggregating behavior to the individual level, future research needs to employ methods such as social network analysis (Wasserman & Faust, 1994) or social relations modeling (Kenny & Lavoie, 1984; Livi, Kenny, Albright, & Pierro, 2008) to understand the nature and pattern of leading–following interactions among actors. In addition, whereas prior research focuses on either leadership or followership behavior, the current theory suggests that it is insufficient to model leadership behavior in a group without consideration of the followership behavior that reciprocates and enables those leadership behaviors to emerge. Thus, future research needs to capture the dynamics between leading and following in groups, and the basic unit of analysis will be the interaction among actors instead of the behavioral tendencies of a single actor.

In addition, I have hopefully made a compelling case for not equating leadership with formal power or supervision. The implication for future research is that it is insufficient for researchers to only examine the leadership behaviors of supervisors or the followership behaviors of subordinates. Rather than assuming the supervisor is the primary source of leadership, researchers should instead assess the leading and following acts of both supervisors and subordinates, and the interactions between the two sources. It is possible that leadership from one source could complement leadership from another source, but it is also possible that multi-source leadership could create conflict over who is leading and who is following. Yet, by leaving open the possibility that leadership can originate from non-designated leaders, this approach to leadership research should provide a more comprehensive understanding of how leading–following processes emerge and evolve in both hierarchical and non-hierarchical settings.

Finally, the present theory emphasizes the importance of dynamism in leading–following interactions, and builds a case for how fluid leader–follower identities and relationships can promote group adaptation and development. Researchers looking to empirically test these ideas will need to employ longitudinal models of change that capture not only changes in leader–follower identities and relationships, but also changes in the group context and environment that would influence or be influenced by the pattern of leading–following interactions. Thus, I join many others in calling for longitudinal research that accounts for the dynamic and temporal aspects of leading–following processes in groups (Ployhart, Holtz, & Bliese, 2002).

4. Conclusion

In the ebbs and flows of scientific progress, there is an emerging perspective that traditional conceptualizations of leadership are incomplete, and that leadership is more complex and more of a social system than prior theory recognizes. For example:

“...leadership (is) a shared influence process in which...any member of a group or social system may carry out at any time.” (Hunt, 2004, p. 25)

“...leadership (is) the process by which social systems change through structuring of roles and relationships...” (Uhl-Bien, 2006, p. 668)

“...any member of the social system may exhibit leadership at any time, and there is no clear distinction between leaders and follower.” (Yukl, 2010, p. 4)

One explanation for this trend in leadership studies is that the nature of work in organizations is changing to include more interdependent work, more fluid and less centralized work structures, and a greater emphasis on the need for leadership at all levels of an organization.

The present theory draws on these perspectives to propose that leadership consists of a series of leading–following double interacts that anyone can participate in. The magnitude and dispersion of these leading–following double interacts produces a distinct pattern of behavior that inputs into a leadership identity construction process, which influences and is influenced by task, relational and organizational environments. It is through this identity construction process that leading–following relationships develop into social structures where some people are seen as leading and others following. Ultimately, groups are more adaptive to the extent that the variability in leader–follower identities and relationships is proportionate with the amount and form of variability in the environment. Consistent with Uhl-Bien et al. (2007), I posit that re-conceptualizing leadership as a complex adaptive process brings attention to the social complexities and emergent properties of leadership in contemporary organizations. By further delineating the leading–following process, I hope to have provided a foundation for theories that move beyond hierarchical, individualistic, one-directional and de-contextualized notions of leadership.

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